

Chapter 1

The Tao that is the subject of discussion is not the true Tao. The quality which can be named is not its true attribute. That which was before Heaven and Earth is called the Non-Existent. The Existent is the mother of all things. Therefore doth the wise man seek aft

Existence is beyond the power of words
To define: Terms may be used But are none of them absolute. In the beginning of heaven and earth there were no words, Words came out of the womb of matter; And whether a man dispassionately Sees to the

The Tao that can be expressed in words is not the eternal Tao. The name that can be defined in words is not the name that never changes. Non-existence is what we will call the source of heaven and earth. Existence is the mother of all things. From eternal non-existence, therefore, we observe the beginning of the existence of the many hidden qualities of the universe. From e

er the first mystery of the Non-Existent, while seeing in that which exists the Ultimates thereof. The Non-Existent and Existent are identical in all but name. This identity of apparent opposites I call the profound, the great deep, the open door of bewilderment. up

core of life Or passionately Sees the surface, The core and the surface Are essentially the same, Words making them seem different Only to express appearance. If name be needed, wonder names them both: From wonder into wonder Existence opens.

ternal existence, therefore, we clearly observe the overt qualities of the universe. These two, the hidden and the overt, are originally the same at source, and become different when they manifest themselves. This same origin is "the smallest of the small." The absolute "smallest of the small" is the gate from which the beginning of all the parts of the universe emerges. up

Chapter 2

When the world speaks of beauty as being beautiful, ugliness is at once defined. When goodness is seen to be good, evil is at once apparent. So do existence and non-existence mutually give rise to one another, as that which is difficult and that which is easy, distant and near, high and low, shrill and bass, preceding and following.

People through finding something beautiful Think something else unbeautiful, Through finding one man fit Judge another unfit. Life and death, though stemming from each other, seem to conflict as stages of change, Difficult and easy as phases of achievement, Long and short as measures of contrast, High and low as degrees of relation; But,

The Sage therefore is occupied only with that which is without prejudice. He teaches without verbosity; he acts without effort; he produces without possessing, he acts without regard to the fruit of action; he brings his work to perfection without assuming credit; and claiming nothing as his own, he cannot at any time be said to lose. up

since the varying of tones gives music to a voice And what is the was of what shall be, The sanest man Sets up no deed, Lays down no law, Takes everything that happens as it comes, As something to animate, not to appropriate, To earn, not to own, To accept naturally without self-importance: If you never assume importance You never lose it.

Chapter 3

Avoiding distinctions of merit among the people prevents jealousy. Not setting a value on rare things prevents theft. Not seeking the things of peace keeps the mind in peace. Thus the Sage governs by ridding the heart of its desires; giving the stomach due

It is better not to make merit a matter of reward Lest people conspire and contend, Not to pile up rich belongings Lest they rob, Not to excite by display Lest they covet. A sound leader's aim is to open people's hearts, Fill thei

satisfaction, by resting the muscles and strengthening the bones, by preserving the world from a knowledge of evil and hence from its desire, and by making those who have such knowledge afraid to use it. He acts by non-action, and by this he governs all. up

r stomachs, Calm their wills, Brace their bones And so to clarify their thoughts and cleanse their needs That no cunning meddler could touch them: Without being forced, without strain or constraint, Good government comes of itself.

Chapter 4

Tao is without
limitation; its
depth is the
source of
whatsoever is. It
makes sharp
things round, it
brings order out
of chaos

Existence, by
nothing bred,
Breeds
everything.
Parent of the
universe, It
smooths rough
edges, Unties
hard knots,
Tempers the

The Tao, if you
examine it, will
always be empty
and will never be
full. In its infinite
emptiness lies
the source of all
things,

, it obscures the
brilliant, it is
wholly without
attachment. I do
not know who
gave it birth; it is
more ancient
than God. up

sharp sun, Lays
blowing dust, Its
image in the
wellspring never
fails. But how
was it
conceived?--this
image Of no
other sire.

It will remain in
its depths
forever. I don't
know whose
seed it is, But it
looks like the
predecessor of
the universe
itself. up

Chapter 5

Neither Heaven
nor Earth has
any
predilections;
they regard all
persons and
things as
sacrificial
images. The
wise man knows
no distinctions;
he beholds all
men as things
made for holy
uses. The
celestial space is
like unto bellow

Nature, immune
as to a sacrifice
of straw dogs,
Faces the decay
of its fruits. A
sound man,
immune as to a
sacrifice of straw
dogs, Faces the
passing of
human
generations. The
un

Heaven and
earth do not own
all things, For
them, things are
like straw dogs.
The sage does
not own his
words, For him,
all people are
like straw dogs.
The hollow
space that lies
between heaven
and earth is like
the

s though
containing
nothing that is
solid, it does not
at any time
collapse; and the
more it is set in
motion, the more
does it produce.
The inflated man,
however, is soon
exhausted. Than
self-restraint
there is nothing
better. up

iverse, like a
bellows, Is
always emptying,
always full: The
more it yields,
the more it holds.
Men came to
their wit's end
arguing about it
And had better
meet it at the
marrow.

blacksmith's
bellows. Hollow
in appearance,
nothing is
lacking, And if it
moves, a lot of
what is in it
moves. The
person who
speaks a lot will
be exhausted. It
would be better
for him to keep
his words to
himself. up

Chapter 6

Like the river in
the valley, the
spirit is never
dried up. I call it
the
Mother-Deep.
The motion of
the Mot

The breath of life
moves through a
deathless valley
Of mysterious
motherhood
Which conceives
and bears the
universal seed, T

"The valley and
the wind will
never die." They
are the creators
of the one who is
the mystical
mother, The one
whose hair i

her-Deep I
regard as the
origin of the
Heaven and the
Earth. Forever it
endures and
moves without
design. up

he seeming of a
world never to
end, Breath for
men to draw
from as they will:
And the more
they take of it,
the more
remains.

s the source of
heaven and
earth. This
source will never
end. Even if it is
exploited
endlessly, it will
never diminish.
up

Chapter 7

Both Heaven and Earth endure a long time. The cause of their endurance is their indifference to long life. This is why the wise man, indifferent

The universe is deathless, is deathless because, having no finite self, it stays infinite. A sound man by not advancing himself stays the further ahead

Heaven and earth will exist forever. The reason they exist forever is that they do not live for themselves and they do not live because of themselves. Therefore they live forever. In the same way, the sage stays behind everything and finds himself in front of everything, he is not himself and he is preserved forever. Since he has no self-interest, his self-interest

to himself, is the greatest among men, and taking no care for himself, he is nevertheless preserved. By being the most unselfish he is the most secure of all. up

ahead of himself, By not confining himself to himself sustains himself outside himself: By never being an end in himself He endlessly becomes himself.

can realize itself. Even though it looks like heaven and earth give life to all creatures, they do not live in order to preserve their own existence, and therefore they live forever and never die. In his rule over the kingdom, the sage does everything for people, ignoring his personal goals, and ultimately earns glory, honor, and everything he wanted for himself. up

Chapter 8

The greatest virtue is like water; it is good to all things. It attains the most inaccessible places without strife. Therefore it is like Tao. It has the virtue of adapting itself to its place. It is virtuous like the heart by being deep.

Man at his best, like water, Serves as he goes along: Like water he seeks his own level, The common level of life, Loves living close to the earth, Living clear down in his heart, Loves kinship with his

It is virtuous like speech by being faithful. It is virtuous like government in regulating. It is virtuous like a servant in its ability. It is virtuous like action by being in season. And because it does not strive it has no enemies. up

neighbors, The pick of words that tell the truth, The even tenor of a well-run state, The fair profit of able dealing, The right timing of useful deeds, And for blocking no one's way No one blames him.

Chapter 9

It is advisable to
refrain from
continual
reaching after
wealth. Continual
handling and
sharpening
wears away the
most durable
thing. If the
house be full

Keep stretching
a bow You
repent of the pull,
A 'whetted saw
Goes thin and
dull, Surrounded
with treasure
You

It is better to
leave a thing
alone Than to
hold it and keep
it full to the brim.
If you sharpen
the blade and
use it, It will not
remain sharp for
long. When gold
and jade fill the
temple, No one
can protect them.
W

of jewels, who
shall protect it?
Wealth and glory
bring care along
with pride. To
stop when good
work is done and
honour
advancing is the
way of Heaven.
up

lie ill at ease,
Proud beyond
measure You
come to your
knees: Do
enough, without
vieing, Be living,
not dying.

hen wealth and
honor come
together with
pride
Self-destruction
quickly joins
them. After the
goal has been
achieved and the
objective has
been honorably
accomplished,
The Tao of
heaven Is to
retire from
everything. up

Chapter 10

By conserving the natural and spiritual powers it is possible to escape dissolution. By restraining the passions and letting gentleness have its sway it is possible to continue as a child. By purging the mind of impurities it is possible to remain untainted. By governing the people with love it is possible to re

Can you hold the door of your tent Wide to the firmament? Can you, with the simple stature Of a child, breathing nature, Become, notwithstanding, A man? Can you continue befriending With no prejudice, no ban? Can you, mating with heaven, Serve as the f

Can you always keep your soul focused So that nothing can divert it from the Tao? Can you regulate your breathing And be as soft and relaxed as a baby? Can you purify yourself and eliminate the hidden So that you are free of all ble

main unknown. By continual use of the Gates of Heaven it is possible to preserve them from rust. By transparency on all sides it is possible to remain unrecognized. o bring forth and preserve, to produce without possessing, to act without hope of reward, and to expand without waste, this is the supreme virtue. up

emale part? Can your learned head take leaven From the wisdom of your heart? If you can bear issue and nourish its growing, If you can guide without claim or strife, If you can stay in the lead of men without their knowing, You are at the core of life.

mish and error? Can you love the people and govern the state by non-action? Can you open and close the gates of nature As a woman can? Can you be enlightened and aware And penetrate to the depths of everything, without knowledge? up

Chapter 11

The thirty spokes
of a carriage
wheel uniting at
the nave are
made useful by
the hole in the
centre, where
nothing exists.
Vessels of
moulded earth
are useful by
reason of the

Thirty spokes are
made one by
holes in a hub,
By vacancies
joining them for a
wheel's use; The
use of clay in
moulding
pitchers Comes
fr

Thirty spokes unite
in the middle of the
wheel, And
because of the
part between them
where nothing
exists, We enjoy
the use of the
carriage wheel.
Clay is formed into
bowls and vessels,
And because of
the hollow in it
where nothing
exists, We use
them as vessels.
Doors and
windows are cut
into the walls of
the house, And
since they are
empty space, we
can use them.
Ther

ir hollowness.
Doors and
windows are
useful by being
cut out. A house
is useful because
of its emptiness.
Existence,
therefore, is like
unto gain, but
Non-Existence to
use. up

om the hollow of
its absence;
Doors, windows,
in a house, Are
used for their
emptiness: Thus
we are helped by
what is not To
use what is.

efore, on the one
hand, we have the
advantage of what
exists, And, on the
other, we utilize
the non-existent.
Without that which
does not exist, we
cannot take
advantage of the
wheel, the vessel,
or the house.
Without wooden
spokes, clay, and
walls, we cannot
take advantage of
the space they
contain. Ultimately,
existence and
non-existence
coexist and are
intertwined. up

Chapter 12

Light will blind a man, sound will make him deaf, taste will ruin his palate, the chase will make him wild, and precious things will temp

The five colors can blind, The five tones deafen, The five tastes cloy. The race, the hunt, can drive men mad And their

The five colors blind a person's sight. The five sounds deafen a person's hearing. The five tastes dull a person's palate. Races and hunting trips make a person wild. Things that are hard to attain are

t him. Therefore soes the wise man provide for the soul and not for the senses. He ignores the one and takes the other with both hands. up

booty leave them no peace. Therefore a sensible man Prefers the inner to the outer eye: He has his yes, --he has his no.

detrimental to a person's conduct. For this reason, the sage Prepares his food according to the size of his stomach and not according to the size of his eyes. He rejects surfeit, and opts for less. up

Chapter 13

Honour and shame are the same as fear. Fortune and disaster are the same as the person. What is said of honour and shame is this: shame is abasement, which is feared whether is be absent or present. So dignity and shame are inseparable from the fear which both occasion. What is said of f

Favor and disfavor have been called equal worries, Success and failure have been called equal ailments. How can favor and disfavor be called equal worries? Because winning favor burdens a man With the fear of losing it. How can success and failure be called equal ailments? Because a man thin

"Honor and disgrace are like fear. Fortune and disaster are like our body." What does "Honor and disgrace are like fear" mean? Honor is located in a high place, and disgrace is located in a low place. When you have them, it is as if you are in a state of fear, and when you no longer have them, it is also as if you are in a state of fear. Therefore, honor and disgrace are like fea

fortune and disaster is this: fortune and disaster are things which befall the person. So without personality how should I suffer disaster or the reverse? Therefore by the accident of good fortune a man may rule the world for a time. But by virtue of love he may rule the world for ever. up

ks of the personal body as self. When he no longer thinks of the personal body as self Neither failure nor success can ail him. One who knows his lot to be the lot of all other men Is a safe man to guide them, One who recognizes all men as members of his own body Is a sound man to guard them.

r. What does "Fortune and disaster are like our body" mean? We have fortune and disaster because we have a body. When we do not have a body, how can fortune and disaster affect us? Therefore, the person who relates to the world like he relates to the good fortune of his body can rule the world. The world can be safely entrusted to the person who loves it like he loves his body. up

Chapter 14

le. Plainness is that which cannot be seen by looking at it. He. Stillness is that which cannot be heard by listening to it. We. Rareness is that which cannot be felt by handling it. These, being indiscernible, may be regarded as an unity - I H W, Tao. It is not bright above nor dark beneath. Infinite in operation, it is yet

What we look for beyond seeing
And call the unseen, Listen for beyond hearing
And call the unheard, Grasp for beyond reaching
And call the withheld, Merge beyond understanding
In a oneness Which does not merely rise and give light,
Does not merely set and leave darkness, But forever sends forth a succession of living thi

What we look at and do not see is called simplicity. What we listen to and do not hear is called rarity. What we clasp and do not catch is called delicateness. These three cannot be discerned, So they unite to become one. When it is revealed, it does not dazzle, When it is concealed, it is not dark, When it is infinite, it is not defined. It attains the non-existent. I

without name. Issuing forth it enters into Itself. This is the appearance of the Non-Apparent, the form of the Non-Existent. This is the unfathomable mystery. Going before, its face is not seen; following after, its back is not observed. Yet to regulate one's life by the ancient knowledge of Tao is to have found the path. up

ngs as mysterious
As the unbegotten existence to which they return. That is why men have called them empty phenomena, Meaningless images, In a mirage With no face to meet, No back to follow. Yet one who is anciently aware of existence Is master of every moment, Feels no break since time beyond time In the way life flows.

ts name is the form of the formless And its image is that which does not have an image. It is mysterious. Meet it, and you will not be able to see its face, Follow it, and you will not be able to see its back. By adhering to the ancient Tao, You will be master of the essence of the present And you will be aware of the origin of the past. That is the clue to the Tao. up

Chapter 15

The ancient wise men were skilful in their mysterious acquaintance with profundities. They were fathomless in their depths; so profound, that I cannot bring them forth to my mind. They were cautious, like one who crosses a swollen river. They were reserved, like one who doubts his fellows. They were watchful, like one who travels abroad. They were retiring, like snow beneath the sun. Th

Long ago the land was ruled with a wisdom Too fine, too deep, to be fully understood And, since it was beyond men's full understanding, Only some of it has come down to us, as in these sayings: 'Alert as a winter-farer on an icy stream,' 'Wary as a man in ambush,' 'Considerate as a welcome guest,' 'Selfless as melting ice,' 'Green as an uncut tree,' 'Open as a valley

ey were simple, like newly felled timber. They were lowly, like the valley. They were obscure, like muddy water. May not a man take muddy water and make it clear by keeping still? May not a man take a dead thing and make it alive by continuous motion? Those who follow this Tao have no need of replenishing, and being devoid of all properties, they grow old without need of being filled. up

, ' And this one also, 'Roiled as a torrent, Why roiled as a torrent? Because when a man is in turmoil how shall he find peace Save by staying patient till the stream clears? How can a man's life keep its course If he will not let it flow? Those who flow as life flows know They need no other force: They feel no wear, they feel no tear, They need no mending, no repair.

Chapter 16

Having emptied yourself of everything, remain where you are. All things spring forth into activity with one accord, and wither do we see them return? After blossoming for a while, everything dies down to its root. This going back to one's origin is called peace: it is the giving of oneself over to the inevitable. This giving of oneself over to the inevitable is called p

Be utterly humble And you shall hold to the foundation of peace. Be at one with all these living things which, having arisen and flourished, Return to the quiet whence they came, Like a healthy growth of vegetation Falling back upon the root. Acceptance of this return to the root has been called 'quietism,' Acceptance of quietism has been condemned as 'fatalism.' But fatalism is ac

Devote yourself to the goal of achieving absolute serenity, Aspire to a state of perfect peace. All things come into existence, And we see them return. Look at the things that bloomed and flowered, Each of them returns to its source. The return to the source is called serenity, Which means following destiny, Following destiny is eternal, it is eternity. He who knows eternity is enlightened. He who does

reservation. He who knows this preservation is called enlightened. He who knows it not continues in misery. He who knows this preservation is great of soul. He who is great of soul is prevailing. Prevailing, he is a king. Being a king, he is celestial. Being celestial, he is of Tao. Being of Tao, he endures for ever: for though his body perish, yet he suffers no hurt. up

ceptance of destiny And to accept destiny is to face life with open eyes, Whereas not to accept destiny is to face death blindfold. He who is open-eyed is open-minded- He who is open-minded is open-hearted, He who is open-hearted is kingly, He who is kingly is godly, He who is godly is useful, He who is useful is infinite, He who is infinite is immune, He who is immune is immortal.

not know eternity runs blindly To his pain and suffering. Knowledge of eternity, is all-embracing. Since he embraces everything, he will achieve greatness. Since he grasps greatness, he can attain perfection. When he reaches perfection, he will attain supremacy. When he is supreme, he will come to the Tao. The person who achieves the Tao exists forever. Even if his body decays, he will never perish. up

Chapter 17

In the first age of mankind the people recognized their superiors. In the second age they served and flattered them. In the third age they feared them, In the fourth age they despised

A leader is best When people barely know that he exists, Not so good when people obey and acclaim him, Worst when they despise him. 'Fail to honor people

The greatest rulers are the ones whose existence the people do not notice at all, The rulers who are inferior to them are the ones whom the people honor and praise, And inferior to those are the ones of whom

them. Where faith is lacking it does not inspire confidence. How careful were they in their expressions! When they had done a good thing they would say, "How very natural we are!" up

e, They fail to honor you;' But of a good leader, who talks little, When his work is done, his aim fulfilled, They will all say, 'We did this ourselves.'

they are afraid, And inferior to those are the ones whom they despise. When there is a lack of faith in the ruler, No one believes in his rule. Now, learn how much importance must be attributed to words. up

Chapter 18

When the great
Tao is lost men
follow after
charity and duty
to one's
neighbours.
When wisdom
has met with
honours the
world is full of
pretenders. Wh

When people lost
sight of the way
to live Came
codes of love
and honesty,
Learning came,
charity came,
Hypocrisy took
charge; When
differences

When the great
Tao is lost,
justice,
righteousness
and good will
spring forth.
When wisdom
and cunning
emerge,
hypocrisy raises
its head. When
family ties are no
longer
harmonious,
honoring parents
and caring fo

en family ties are
severed then
filial duty and
parental
indulgence take
their place When
a nation is filled
with strife then
do patriots
flourish. up

weakened family
ties Came
benevolent
fathers and
dutiful sons; And
when lands were
disrupted and
misgoverned
Came ministers
commended as
loyal.

r children still
remain. When a
nation is in a
state of
confusion and
disorder,
patriotism
becomes
evident. When
Tao is present,
equilibrium is
present. When
Tao is lost, the
differences
between things
emerge. up

Chapter 19

By giving up their self-righteousness and abandoning their wisdom the people would be immensely improved. Forsaking Charity and Duty to the neighbours, they might revert to their natural relations. Abandoning excellence and foregoing gain, the people would

Rid of formalized wisdom and learning People would be a hundredfold happier, Rid of conventionalized duty and honor People would find their families dear, Rid of legalized profiteering People would have

Abandon learning, And grief and sorrow will no longer be known. Abandon learned volumes, cast off wisdom, And people will be one hundred times better off. Abandon righteousness, cast off justice, And people will return to filial duty and birthing offspring. Abandon cunning, cast off avarice

and have no more thieves. The cultivation of these things has been a failure, therefore they should go back whence they came. And for you, do come forth in your natural simplicity, lay hold on verities, restrain selfishness, and rid yourself of ambition. up

and have no thieves to fear. These methods of life have failed, all three, Here is the way, it seems to me: Set people free, As deep in their hearts they would like to be, From private greeds And wanton needs.

And bandits and thieves will disappear from the earth. These four principles, even if they form the foundation of human culture, are not sufficient. Therefore, here are principles to which people can adhere: Show integrity, adhere to simplicity, Restrain selfishness, curtail lusts. up

Chapter 20

Chapter 21

The greatest
virtue is in simply
following Tao,
the intangible,
inscrutable.
Inscrutable,
intangible, and
yet containing
forms. Intangible,
inscrutable, and
yet containing
things. Profound
and obscure, but
having an

The surest test if
a man be sane is
if he accepts life
whole, as it is,
Without needing
by measure or
touch to
understand The
measureless
untouchable
source Of its
images, The
measureless
untouchable
source Of its
substances,

The
manifestation of
the great virtue is
to follow the way
of the Tao. Tao is
a thing that is
invisible,
inaccessible.
Inaccessible,
invisible, and yet
it has image and
form. Cloudy and
obscure, but
there is essence
in it, And this es

essence, a
veritable
essence in which
is consistence.
From eternity
until now its
nature has
remained
unchanged. It
inheres in all
things from their
beginnings. How
do I know of the
origin of things? I
know by Tao. up

The source
which, while it
appears dark
emptiness, Brims
with a quick force
Farthest away
And yet nearest
at hand From
oldest time unto
this day,
Charging its
images with
origin: What
more need I
know of the
origin Than this?

sence is absolute
truth, and there
is belief in it.
From ancient
times until now, it
has not lost its
nameless name,
Through it the
source of all
things has
passed. How do I
know that the
source of all
things is in it?
From the Tao. up

Chapter 22

'Yield and you
need not break:'
Bent you can
straighten,
Emptied you can
hold, Torn you can
mend; And as
want can reward
you So wealth can
bewilder. Aware of
this, a wise man
has the simple
return Which other
men seek: Without
inflaming himself
He is kindled

Be modest, and
you will remain
whole. Be bent,
and you will
remain straight. Be
empty, and you
will remain full. Be
worn out, and you
will remain new.
The one who has
little will receive.
The one who has
a lot will be
enslaved.
Therefore the sage
guards the one,
And becomes a
paradigm for the
world. He does not
expose himself,
therefore he
shines. He does
not make a good
name for hi

therefore he
shines. He is not
egotistic, and
therefore he is
praised. He is not
vain, therefore he
is esteemed. He is
not haughty, and
therefore he is
honoured. And
because he does
not compete with
others, no man is
his enemy. The
ancient maxim,
"Whosoever
adapteth himself
shall be preserved
to the end," verily it
is no idle saying.
Without doubt he
shall go back to
his Home in
peace. up

, Without
explaining himself
Is explained,
Without taking
credit Is
accredited, Laying
no claim Is
acclaimed And,
because he does
not compete,
Finds peaceful
competence. How
true is the old
saying, 'Yield and
you need not
break'! How
completely it
comes home!

mself, therefore he
is known. He does
not praise himself,
therefore he is
dear to everyone.
He does not glorify
himself, therefore
his name is on
everyone's lips.
And since he does
not compete at all,
There is no one in
the world who can
compete with him.
The ancient ones
said: Be modest,
and you will
remain whole. Can
these be
meaningless
words? Indeed, he
will return home
whole. up

Chapter 23

Moderate your speech, and preserve yourself. A hurricane will not outlast the morning, a heavy rain will not outlast the day. Who have the power to make these things but Heaven and Earth? And if Heaven and Earth cannot continue them long, how shall a man do so? If a man accords with Tao in all things, he is identified with Tao by that agreement. A virtuous man

Nature does not have to insist, Can blow for only half a morning, Rain for only half a day, And what are these winds and these rains but natural? If nature does not have to insist, Why should man? It is natural too That whoever follows the way of life feels alive, That whoever

It is natural to be frugal with words. A gale will not blow for an entire morning; Pelting rain will not fall for a whole day. Who causes all those? Heaven and earth. If (the fruit of) heaven and earth cannot last forever, How can man? The person who follows the Tao, Is identified with the Tao. T

is identified with virtue, a vicious man is identified with vice. Whoever is identified with Tao, him do the Taoists receive with gladness. Whoever is identified with virtue, him do the virtuous receive with gladness. But whoever is identified with vice, him do the vicious gladly serve with vice. For wherever confidence is lacking, it is not met with trust. up

uses it properly feels well used, Whereas he who loses the way of life feels lost, That whoever keeps to the way of life Feels at home, Whoever uses it properly Feels welcome, Whereas he who uses it improperly Feels improperly used: 'Fail to honor people, They fail to honor you.

he person who adheres to virtue, Is identified with virtue. The person who adheres to vice, Is identified with vice. When a person follows the Tao, The Tao looks kindly upon him. When the person adheres to virtue, Virtue welcomes him. When the person adheres to vice, Vice opens its door to him. up

Chapter 24

By standing on tiptoe one cannot keep still. Astride of one's fellow one cannot progress. By displaying oneself one does not shine. By self-approbation one is not esteemed. In self-praise there is n

Standing tiptoe a man loses balance, Walking astride he has no pace, Kindling himself he fails to light, Acquitting himself he forfeits his hearers, Admiring himself he does so alone. Pride

A person who stands on tiptoe cannot stand firmly on his feet. A person who spreads his legs cannot walk steadily. A person who displays himself cannot shine (like a star in the sky). A person who praises himself will not be praised by others. A person who glorifies himself will not be famous. A person who ma

o merit. He who exalts himself does not stand high. Such things are to Tao what refuse and excreta are to the body. They are everywhere detested. Therefore the man of Tao will not abide with them. up

has never brought a man greatness But, according to the way of life, Brings the ills that make him unfit, Make him unclean in the eyes of his neighbor, And a sane man will have none of them.

kes himself mighty cannot excel. All these, in comparison to the Tao, are called: "A surfeit of food and an excess of action." They will be tiresome to everyone in other things, too. Therefore, the man of Tao is not found in their company. All these are examples of living in a way that goes against nature. up

Chapter 25

Before Heaven
and Earth existed
there was in
Nature a
primordial
substance. It was
serene, it was
fathomless. It was
self-existent, it was
homogeneous. It
was omnipresent,
nor suffered any
limitation. It is to
be regarded as the
universal mother. I
do not know its
name, but I call it
Tao. If forced to
qualify it, I call it
the boundless.
Being boundless, I
call it the i

Before creation a
presence existed,
Self-contained,
complete,
Formless,
voiceless,
mateless,
Changeless,
Which yet
pervaded itself
With unending
motherhood.
Though there can
be no name for it, I
have called it 'the
way of life.'
Perhaps I should
have called it 'the
fullness of life,'
Since fullness
implies widening
into space, Implies
still further widenin

There is
something that is
overt and hidden,
That exists beyond
heaven and earth.
Formless,
motionless, It
stands alone,
forever, it does not
change, It exists in
every place, it
never tires. It can
be called "Mother
of the universe,"
Because I don't
know its name. If I
am compelled to
call it by a name, I
will call it Tao,
"all-embracing."
"All-embracing"
exists forever,
"All-embracing" i

nconceivable.
Being inscrutable,
I call it the
inaccessible.
Being
inaccessible, I call
it the omnipresent.
Tao is supreme,
Heaven is
supreme, Earth is
supreme, the King
is supreme. There
are in the universe
four kinds of
supremacy, and
their rulership is
one. Man is ruled
by the Earth, the
Earth is ruled by
Heaven, Heaven is
ruled by Tao, and
Tao is ruled by
itself. up

g, Implies
widening until the
circle is whole. In
this sense The
way of life is
fulfilled, Heaven is
fulfilled, Earth
fulfilled And a fit
man also is
fulfilled: These are
the four
amplitudes of the
universe And a fit
man is one of
them: Man
rounding the way
of earth, Earth
rounding the way
of heaven, Heaven
rounding the way
of life Till the circle
is full.

Chapter 26

Weight underlies
lightness,
quiescence
underlies motion.
Therefore the
Sage never loses
his gravity and
quiescence from
day to day.
Though glorious
palaces should
belong to him, he
would dwell in
them

Gravity is the
root of grace,
The mainstay of
all speed. A
traveler of true
means, whatever
the day's pace,
Remembers the
provision-van
And, however
fine prospect be
off

Heaviness is the
basis of lightness,
The passing is the
basis of
movement,
Therefore the
sage, even when
traveling all day
long, Never
abandons the
baggage wagon,
Therefore the
sage, even when
surrounded by
splendor and
luxury, Is shrouded
in indifference that
stems from
serenity. How can
this great emperor,
with a thousand
chariots, Move
easily throughout
his kingdom? If

peacefully,
without
attachment. Alas
that a king with
many chariots
should conduct
himself with
frivolity in the
midst of his
kingdom! By
levity he loses
his ministers,
and by
inconstancy his
throne. up

ered, is a man
With a calm
head. What lord
of countless
chariots would
ride them in vain,
Would make
himself fool of
the realm, With
pace beyond
rein, Speed
beyond helm?

he is light, he will
lose his basis, If
he is hasty, he will
lose his serenity.
Wang-Pi
comments: The
light cannot bear
the heavy; the
small cannot
contain the large;
the sedentary
controls the
moving, the one
who does not
move from his
place controls the
one who moves
from his place.
Therefore
heaviness is the
basis of lightness,
and serenity is the
secret of control.
up

Chapter 27

A good walker makes no dust after him. The good speaker incurs no discussion. The good reckoner needs no arithmetic. The good keeper needs no bolts or bars, and none can open after him. The wise man is constant and a good helper of his fellows. He rejects none. He is a continual good preserver of things.

One may move so well that a foot-print never shows, Speak so well that the tongue never slips, Reckon so well that no counter is needed, Seal an entrance so tight, though using no lock, That it cannot be opened, Bind a hold so firm, though using no cord, That it cannot be untied. And these are traits not only of a sound man But of many a

The good traveler leaves no tracks, The good speaker leaves no doubt, The good accountant needs no abacus, The good builder needs no lock and bolt, And the door he closes will not open behind him. The good fastener needs no ropes or knots, And it is still impossible to untie after him. Even if people are bad, why should they be rejected? Therefore the sage is always the good savior of the people, And nobody will

He disdains nothing. His intelligence is all-embracing. Good men instruct one another; and bad men are the material they delve in. Whoever, therefore, does not honour his teacher and cherish his material, though he be called wise, is yet in a state of delusion. This is no less important than strange. up

man thought to be unsound. A sound man is good at salvage, At seeing that nothing is lost. Having what is called insight, A good man, before he can help a bad man, Finds in himself the matter with the bad man. And whichever teacher Discounts the lesson Is as far off the road as the other, Whatever else he may know. That is the heart of it.

I reject him. He is good to all creatures, He spurns nothing. This state is called "to see and to come to the light." Therefore, good people are guides to bad people, And many people are like matter in good people's hands. And the person who does not appreciate his guide, And the person who does not love the matter in his hand, All their success comes from blindness. This is the main principle of the secret. up

Chapter 28

He who, being a man, remains a woman, will become an universal channel. As an universal channel the eternal virtue will never forsake him. He will re-become a child. He who, being in the light, remains in obscurity, will become an universal model. As an universal model the eternal virtue will not pass him by. He will go back to the all-perfect. He who, being glorious, continu

'One who has a man's wings And a woman's also Is in himself a womb of the world' And, being a womb of the world, Continuously, endlessly, Gives birth; One who, preferring light, Prefers darkness also Is in himself an image of the world And, being an image of the world, Is continuously, endlessly The dwe

es in humility, will become an universal valley. As an universal valley the eternal virtue will fill him. He will revert to the first essence. This first essence is that which, being differentiated, gives rise to innumerable vessels of life. A wise man, by embracing it, becomes the wisest of governors. A liberal government is that which neither disregards nor hurts anyone. up

lling of creation; One who is highest of men And humblest also Is in himself a valley of the world, And. being a valley of the world, Continuously, endlessly Conducts the one source From which vessels may be usefully filled; Servants of the state are such vessels, To be filled from undiminishing supply.

Chapter 29

When a man
who wishes to
reform the world
takes it in hand, I
perceive that
there will be no
end to it! Spiritual
vessels are not
fashioned in the
world. Whoever
makes destroys;
whoever grasps
loses. For
perforce if one
advance

Those who would
take over the earth
And shape it to
their will Never, I
notice, succeed.
The earth is like a
vessel so sacred
That at the mere
approach of the
profane It is
marred And when
they reach out
their fingers it is
gone. For a time in
the world some
force themselves
ahead And some
are left behind, For

When a person
undertakes to hold
and mold the
world, I see that he
will fail in this task.
Since the world is
an instrument of
God: It cannot be
molded, It cannot
be held. He who
tries to mold it
damages it, He
who insists on
holding it loses it.
Therefore the sage
does not mold it,
and therefore he
does not damage
it, He does no

s another is left
behind; if one
blows hot
another will blow
cold; if one be
strengthened
another will be
weakened; is
one be
supported
another will be
undermined.
Therefore the
Sage gives up all
enthusiasm,
levity, and pomp.
up

a time in the world
some make a
great noise And
some are held
silent, For a time in
the world some
are puffed fat And
some are kept
hungry, For a time
in the world some
push aboard And
some are tipped
out: At no time in
the world will a
man who is sane
Over-reach
himself,
Over-spend
himself, Over-rate
himself.

t try to hold it, and
therefore he does
not lose it. With all
things, some move
forward while
others lag behind,
Some hold their
tongues, while
others speak a lot,
Some are strong,
while others are
weak, Some are
on the wagon,
while others fall
off. Therefore the
sage avoids
excess,
extremism,
haughtiness, lust,
and arrogance. up

Chapter 30

The man who aids the King by use of Tao forces the people into submission without resort to the use of arms. He will not regard the fruit of his actions. Prickly briars and thorns flourish where battalions have quartered. Bad years follow on the heels of armies in motion. The good soldier is brave when occasion requires, but he does not risk himself

One who would guide a leader of men in the uses of life Will warn him against the use of arms for conquest. Weapons often turn upon the wielder, An army's harvest is a waste of thorns, Conscription of a multitude of men Drains the next year dry. A good general, daring to march, dares also to halt, Will never pres

The person who helps a ruler of men with the Tao Does not force the world with weapons. He aims only to redeem the Tao, And does not attempt to force his strength on others. Bringing redemption, he does not attribute it to himself, He does not boast much, he is

for power. Brave is he when occasion requires, but he does not oppress. Brave is he when occasion requires, but he does not boast. Brave is he when occasion requires, but he is not mean. Brave is he when occasion requires, but he does not rage. Things become old through excess of vigour. This is called Non-Tao; and what is Non-Tao is soon wasted! up

s his triumph beyond need. What he must do he does but not for glory, What he must do he does but not for show, What he must do he does but not for self; He has done it because it had to be done, Not from a hot head. Let life ripen and then fall, Force is not the way at all: Deny the way of life and you are dead.

not proud, He thinks that it is his obligation to do so. This is how redemption will be, without force. When things reach their full power, They begin their process of aging. This goes against the Tao. Whatever goes against the Tao will quickly come to an end. up

Chapter 31

Even the finest
arms are an
instrument of evil,
A spread of
plague, And the
way for a vital man
to go is not the
way of a soldier.
But in time of war
men civilized in
peace Turn from
their higher to their
lower nature. Arms
are an instrument
of evil, No
measure for
thoughtful men
Until there fail all
other choice But
sad acceptance of
it. Triumph is not
beautiful. He who
thinks t

riumph beautiful Is
one with a will to
kill, And one with a
will to kill Shall
never prevail upon
the world. It is a
good sign when
man's higher
nature comes
forward, A bad
sign when his
lower nature
comes forward,
When retainers
take charge And
the master stays
back As in the
conduct of a
funeral. The death
of a multitude is
cause for
mourning: Conduct
your triumph as a
funeral.

Chapter 32

Tao the absolute
has no name. But
although
insignificant in its
original simplicity,
the world does not
presume to
bemean it. If a king
could lay hold on
it, the world would
of itself submit to
him. Heaven and
Earth would
conspire to nourish
him. The people
without pressure
would peace

Existence is
infinite, not to be
defined; And,
though it seem but
a bit of wood in
your hand, to
carve as you
please, It is not to
be lightly played
with and laid
down. When rulers
adhered to the
way of life, They
were upheld by
natural loyalty:
Heaven and earth
were joined and
made fertile, Life
was a freshness of
rain, Subje

The Tao was
always
nameless. When
it was expressed
for the first time,
It was given a
name. And once
it has already

ully fall into their
own places. If he
should dispose
them by titles and
names, he would
be making a name
for himself. Yet he
would wisely stop
short of the name,
and thus avoid the
evil of distinctions.
Tao is to the world
what the streams
and valleys are to
the great rivers
and seas. up

ct to none, Free to
all. But men of
culture came, with
their grades and
their distinctions;
And as soon as
such differences
had been devised
No one knew
where to end
them, Though the
one who does
know the end of all
such differences Is
the sound man:
Existence Might be
likened to the
course Of many
rivers reaching the
one sea.

been given a
name, it is
necessary to
stop. The
knowledge of
where to stop
makes a person
immune to any
danger. up

Chapter 33

He is wise who knows others. He who knows himself is enlightened. He is strong who conquers others. He who conquers himself is mighty. He is rich who i

Knowledge studies others, Wisdom is self-known; Muscle masters brothers, Self-mastery is bone; Cont

The person who knows others is wise, The person who knows himself is enlightened. The person who conquers others is strong, The person who conquers himself is powerful. The person who knows his lot is rich. The person who maintains his path with energy has a strong will. The pe

s well satisfied. He walks fast who has an object. He who fills his place remains secure. He who dies without being corrupted enjoys a good old age. up

ent need never borrow, Ambition wanders blind: Vitality cleaves to the marrow Leaving death behind.

rson who does not stray from his proper place will have a long life. The person who dies but does not perish will exist forever. Feo-tzu says: "The difficulty in knowing is not learning others, but learning ourselves. Therefore, the person who learns himself is enlightened." up

Chapter 34

Mighty Tao is all pervading. It is simultaneously on this side and on that. All living things subsist from it, and all are in its care. It works, it finishes, and knows not the name of merit. In love it nurtures all things, and claims no excellence therein. It kn

Bountiful life, letting anyone attend, Making no distinction between left or right. Feeding everyone, refusing no one, Has not provided this bounty to show how much it owns, Has not fed and clad its guests with any thought of claim

The great Tao is in everything, both on the left and on the right. Through it, all things come into being, and it does not abandon them. When its work is completed, it does not possess them. It loves and nurtures all things, But does not rul

ows neither ambition nor desire. It can be classed with the humblest of things. All things finally revert to it, and it is not thereby increased. It can be mentioned with the greatest of things. Thus does the wise man continually refrain from self-distinction. up

; And, because it lacks the twist Of mind or body in what it has done, The guile of head or hands, Is not always respected by a guest. Others appreciate welcome from the perfect host Who, barely appearing to exist, Exists the most.

e them. It never exists, so it can be called small, apparently. All things return home to it, And it does not claim to own them, So it can be called great, apparently. It never aspires to greatness, And therefore it accomplishes greatness. up

Chapter 35

Attain to the
Great Idea, and
all the world will
flock to you. It
will flock to you
and will not be
hurt therein, for it
will rest in a
wonderful peace.
Where there is a
festival the wayf

If the sign of life
is in your face He
who responds to
it Will feel secure
and fit As when,
in a friendly
place, Sure of
hearty care, A tra

The person who
holds the great
thing Will go
through a whole
world. He will go
along the path
straightforwardly
without seeing
danger, But finds
tranquillity,
friendship, and
equality. The
sounds of a tune
and the scent of
delicacies will
cause

arer will stay. To
the palate the
Tao is insipid
and tasteless. In
regarding it the
eye is not
impressed. In
listening to it the
ear is not filled.
But in its uses it
is inexhaustible.
up

veler gladly
waits. Though it
may not taste
like food And he
may not see the
fare Or hear a
sound of plates,
How endless it is
and how good!

the stranger
passing by to
stop. But Tao,
when it is
expressed in
words, is pure,
devoid of all
taste. When
someone looks
at it, he won't see
it. When
someone listens
to it, he won't
hear it. However,
when someone
uses it, it is
everything. up

Chapter 36

When Nature is about to withhold a thing it is sure first to increase it. When about to weaken it is first sure to strengthen. When about to debase it is certain first to exalt. When about to deprive it is first sure

He who feels punctured Must once have been a bubble, He who feels unarmed Must have carried arms, He who feels belittled Must have been consequential, He who feels deprived Must have had privi

In order to reduce something, it must first be expanded. In order to weaken something, it must first be strengthened. In order to drop something, it must first be lifted. "In order to take, a man must first give."

to give. This is what I call the covert agreement. The soft and the weak overcome the hard and the strong. As a fish out of water is in danger, so a nation is in peril when its armaments are revealed to the people. up

lege, Whereas a man with insight Knows that to keep under is to endure. What happens to a fish pulled out of a pond? Or to an implement of state pulled out of a scabbard? Unseen, they survive.

This is what is called the wisdom of light. The soft and weak can overcome the hard and strong. Just as the fish should not leave the depths, The sharp instruments of control should not leave their hiding-place. up

Chapter 37

Tao remains
quiescent, and
yet leaves
nothing undone.
If a ruler or a king
could hold it, all
things would of
their own accord
assume the
desired shape. If
in the process of
transformation
desire s

The way to use
life is to do
nothing through
acting, The way
to use life is to do
everything
through being.
When a leader
knows this, His
land naturally
goes straight.
And the world's
passio

ould arise, I
would check it by
the ineffable
simplicity. The
ineffable
simplicity would
bring about an
absence of
desire, and rest
would come back
again. Thus the
world would
regenerate itself.
up

n to stray from
straightness Is
checked at the
core By the
simple
unnamable
cleanness
Through which
men cease from
coveting, And to
a land where
men cease from
coveting Peace
comes of course.

Chapter 40

The path of the
Tao is backward.
The
characteristic of
Tao is
gentleness.
Every

Life on its way
returns into a
mist, Its
quickness is its
quietness again:
E

Going back is the
movement of the
Tao, Weakening
is the expression
of the Tao.
Everything

thing in the
universe comes
from existence,
and existence
from
non-existence.
up

xistence of this
world of things
and men
Renews their
never needing to
exist.

in the universe
springs from
within existence,
And existence
springs from
non-existence.
up

Chapter 41

When a wise man hears the Tao, he follows it. When one of average mind hears it, he holds to it a while and presently loses it. When a foolish man hears it, he only laughs at it. If it were not held in derision by such men, it could not rightly be called Tao. Therefore, as the verse-makers would say:- Who shines with Tao is lost in shade; His path in Tao is retrograde, And all his actions are obscure. The

Men of stamina, knowing the way of life, Steadily keep to it; Unstable men, knowing the way of life, Keep to it or not according to occasion; Stupid men, knowing the way of life And having once laughed at it, laugh again the louder. If you need to be sure which way is right, you can tell by their laughing at it. They fling the old charges: 'A wick without oil,' 'For every step forward a step or two back.'

Non-existence can penetrate the hardest of all. Therefore I know that there is usefulness to non-acti

To such laughers a level road looks steep, Top seems bottom, 'White appears black, 'Enough is a lack,' Endurance is a weakness, Simplicity a faded flower. But eternity is his who goes straight round the circle, Foundation is his who can feel beyond touch, Harmony is his who can hear beyond sound, Pattern is his who can see beyond shape: Life is his who can tell beyond words Fulfillment of the unfulfilled.

on. Learning without words, usefulness without action, Only a few in the world have achieved this. up

Chapter 42

Tao emaned the One; the one emaned the Two; and the two emaned the Three. From the Three all things have proceeded. All things are backed by the Unmanifest and faced by the Manifest. That which unites them is the immaterial breath. Orphanage, isolation, and a chariot without wheels are shunned by the people; but kings and great

Life, when it came to be, Bore one, then two, then three Elements of things; And thus the three began -Heaven and earth and man- To balance happenings: Cool night behind, warm day ahead, For the living, for the dead. Though a commoner be loth to say That he is only common clay,

Your reputation or your person, which is closer to you? Your person or your property, which is dearer to you? Profit or loss, which is worse for you? Over-eagerness leads to over-spending. Too mu

men appropriate these names to themselves. For things increase by being deprived; and being added to they are diminished. That which people teach by their actions I make use of to instruct them. Those who are violent and headstrong, for example, do not die a natural death. They teach a good lesson, and so I make use of them. up

Kings and princes often state How humbly they are leading, Because in true succeeding High and low correlate. It is an ancient thought, Which many men have taught, That he who over-reaches And tries to live by force Shall die thereby of course, And is what my own heart teaches.

ch property leads to too much loss. Therefore, the person who is content with his lot will not know disgrace, And the person who knows where to stop will never disappear, He will exist forever. up

Chapter 43

The gentlest
thing in the world
will override the
strongest. The
Non-Existent
pervades
everything,
though there be
no inlet. By this I

As the soft yield
of water cleaves
obstinate stone,
So to yield with
life solves the
insoluble: To yiel

comprehend how
effectual is
non-action. To
teach without
words and to be
useful without
action, few
among men are
capable of this.
up

d, I have learned,
is to come back
again. But this
unworded
lesson, This easy
example, Is lost
upon men.

Chapter 44

Which is neared
to you, your
name or your
person? Which is
more precious,
your person or
your wealth?
Which is the
greater evil, to
gain or to lose?
Great devotion
requir

Which means
more to you, You
or your renown?
Which brings
more to you, You
or what you
own? And which
would cost you
more If it we

Tao begets one,
One begets two,
Two begets
three, Three
begets all things.
All things, back
to the shade,
front to the light,
The harmony
between the

es great
sacrifice. Great
wealth implies
great loss. He
who is content
can never be
ruined. He who
stands still will
never meet
danger. These
are the people
who endure. up

re gone? The
niggard pays,
The miser loses.
The least
ashamed of men
Goes back if he
chooses: He
knows both
ways, He starts
again.

m is the breath of
life. What others
teach, I also
teach: "The cruel
and violent do
not die a natural
death." I will use
that sentence as
my guide. up

Chapter 45

He who sees that
his highest
attainments are
always
incomplete may
go on working
indefinitely. He
who sees his
greatest
possessions to
be inadequate
may go on
acquiring forever.
His highest
rectitude is

A man's work,
however finished
it seem,
Continues as
long as he live; A
man, however
perfect he seem,
Is needed as
long as he live:
As long as truth
appears falsity,
The seer a f

The greatest
perfection looks
flawed, And even
so, it never
perishes. The
greatest fullness
looks empty, And
even so, it will
never run out.
The straightest
road looks
crooked. The
greatest vigor loo

but crookedness.
His greatest
wisdom is but
foolishness. His
sweetest
eloquence is but
stammering.
Action
overcomes cold;
inaction
overcomes heat.
With virtue and
quietness one
may conquer the
world. up

ool, The prophet
a dumb lout, If
you want to keep
warm keep
stirring about,
Keep still if you
want to keep
cool, And in all
the world one
day no doubt
Your way shall
be the rule.

ks like laziness,
The greatest
eloquence looks
like stammering.
Action
overcomes cold,
Tranquillity
overcomes heat.
Only through
purity and
tranquillity of
spirit Can order
be imposed on
the world. up

Chapter 46

When Tao is in the world, horses are used in the pastureland. When Tao has left the world, chargers are reared in the wilderness. There is no greater sin than indulging desi

In a land where the way of life is understood Race-horses are led back to serve the field; In a land where the way of life is not understood War-horses are

When Tao rules the world Racehorses are harnessed to the garbage cart in the fields. When Tao does not rule the world War-horses graze in the meadows on the outskirts of the city. There is no greater sin than going after what man desires, There is no greater s

re. There is no greater pain than discontent. There is nothing more disastrous than the greed of gain. Hence the satisfaction of contentment is an everlasting competence. up

bred on the autumn yield. Owning is the entanglement, Wanting is the bewilderment, Taking is the presentiment: Only he who contains content Remains content.

orrow than not knowing a measure of contentment, There is no greater obstacle than falling into the pit of greed. Therefore, it is sufficient for you to know a measure of contentment in order to know contentment in proportion, so as to satisfy your measure. up

Chapter 47

A man may know
the world without
leaving his own
home. Through
his windows he
can see the
supreme Tao.
The further afield
he goes the less
likely

There is no need
to run outside
For better
seeing, Nor to
peer from a
window. Rather
abide At the
center of your
being; For t

Without crossing
the threshold of
the gate It is
possible to know
the entire world.
Without looking
through the
window It is
possible to see
the Tao of
heaven. The
further the
person

is he to find it.
Therefore the
wise man knows
without travelling,
names things
without seeing
them, and
accomplishes
everything
without action.
up

he more you
leave it, the less
you learn.
Search your
heart and see If
he is wise who
takes each turn:
The way to do is
to be.

goes, The less
he knows.
Therefore the
sage Knows
everything
without going
through the
streets, Names
everything
without seeing it,
Accomplishes
every task
without doing
anything. up

Chapter 48

Bodily and mental distress is increased every day in the effort to get knowledge. But this distress is daily diminished by the getting of Tao. Do you continually curtail your effort till there be nothing left of it? B

A man anxious for knowledge adds more to himself every minute; A man acquiring life loses himself in it, Has less and less to bear in mind, Less and less to do, Because life, he finds

The person who pursues his studies Will be wiser with every passing day, The person who seeks the Tao Will decrease with every passing day. Less and less, he will continue to decrease, Until he reaches the state of non-action, And by non-action it is

y non-action there is nothing which cannot be effected. A man might, without the least distress, undertake the government of the world. But those who distress themselves about governing the world are not fit for it. up

, is well inclined, Including himself too. Often a man sways the world like a wind But not by deed; And if there appear to you to be need Of motion to sway it, it has left you behind.

possible to do everything. Li Chia-mou said: "He who pursues learning acquires knowledge; he who seeks the Tao casts off his ignorance. The more the person knows, the more he has to get rid of. Therefore, adding means nothing more than decreasing." up

Chapter 49

The wise man
has no fixed
opinions to call
his own. He
accommodates
himself to the
minds of others. I
would return
good for good; I
would also return
evil for evil.
Virtue is good. I
would meet trust
with trust; I would
likewise mee

A sound man's
heart is not shut
within itself But is
open to other
people's hearts: I
find good people
good, And I find
bad people good
If I am good
enough;

The sage has no
self that he can
call "mine," He
turns the self of
the people into his
own. I act with
goodness toward
the good, I act with
goodness toward
the bad, too, And
so the good is
contagious. I relate
with trust to the
person who is
worthy of trust, I
relate with trust to t

t suspicion with
confidence.
Virtue is trustful.
The wise man
lives in the world
with modest
restraint, and his
heart goes out in
sympathy to all
men. The people
give him their
confidence, and
he regards them
all as his
children. up

I trust men of
their word, And I
trust liars If I am
true enough; I
feel the
heart-heats of
others Above my
own If I am
enough of a
father, Enough of
a son.

he person who is
not worthy of trust,
too, And so trust is
contagious. The
sage lives in the
world in his victory
and rules the world
with his simplicity.
But when all the
people look at him
and listen to him,
The sage takes
care of them, like a
mother takes care
of her children. up

Chapter 50

Men go forth from
Life and enter into
Death. The Gates
of Life are thirteen
in number; and the
same are the
Gates of Death. By
as many ways
does life pass
quickly into Death.
And wherefore?
Because men
strive only after the
Sensuous Life. It
has been said that
one who knows
how to safeguard
Life can go
through the coun

Death might
appear to be the
issue of life, Since
for every three out
of ten being born
Three out of ten
are dying. Then
why Should
another three out
of ten continue
breeding death?
By use of sheer
madness to
multiply. But there
is one out of ten,
they say, s

It is easy to hold
something that is
motionless, It is
easy to create a
mold for
something that is
not lacking, It is
easy to break
something that is
breakable, It is
easy to scatter a
thing that is
small. Take care
o

try without
protection against
the rhinoceros and
tiger. He may
enter into battle
without fear of the
sword. The
rhinoceros finds no
place wherein to
drive his horn. The
tiger finds no place
wherein to fix his
claws. The sword
finds no place
wherein to thrust
itself. Why is this?
It is because he
has overcome
Death. up

o sure of life That
tiger and wild bull
keep clear of his
inland path.
Weapons turn
from him on the
battle-field, No
bull-horn could tell
where to gore him,
No tiger-claw
where to tear him,
No weapon where
to enter him. And
why? Because he
has no death to
die.

f a thing before it
happens,
Arrange a thing
before it gets out
of hand. The
simple man
generally fails in
his affairs on the
verge of
success. Take
care of the end
as you do of the
beginning, And
you will not fail.
up

Chapter 51

Tao brings forth
and Teh
nourishes. All
things take up their
several forms, and
natural forces
bring them to
perfection.
Therefore all
things conspire to
exalt Tao and to
cherish virtue. But
this regard of Tao
and Teh is not in
deference to any
mandate. It is
unconstr

Existence having
born them And
fitness bred
them, While
matter varied
their forms And
breath
empowered
them, All created
things render, to
the existence
and fitness they
depend on, An
obedience Not
commanded but
of course. And
since this i

The Tao created
all things, The way
of the Tao
nourished them,
All things emerge
in different forms,
Each of them is
perfect in the
nature of the Tao
within it.
Therefore, there is
not one among the
myriad of things
That does not
honor the Tao and
cherish its way.
Honoring the Tao
and cherishing its
way are not
dictated by law,
But rather come
from within.
Therefore the Tao
creates

ained, and
therefore it
endures forever.
For Tao produces
all things, and Teh
nourishes,
increases, feeds,
matures, protects,
and watches over
them. To produce
without
possessing; to
work without
expecting; to
enlarge without
usurping; this is
the absolute virtue!
up

s the way
existence bears
issue And fitness
raises, attends,
Shelters, feeds
and protects, DO
you likewise Be
parent, not
possessor,
Attendant, not
master, Be
concerned not
with obedience
but with benefit,
And you are at
the core of living.

them, makes them
grow, nourishes
them, Guards
them, lifts them,
and protects them.
When all things
are created, the
Tao does not
reject them. It
creates them
without owning
them. It operates
without depending
on them, and
raises them
without controlling
them. When its
work is completed,
it does not lay any
claim to them.
Since it does not
lay claim to them,
it does not lose
them. up

Chapter 52

That from which
the universe
sprang may be
looked upon as its
Mother. By
knowing the
Mother you have
access to the
child. And if,
knowing the child,
you prefer the
Mother, though
your body perish,
yet you will come
to no harm. Keep
your mouth shut,
and close up the
doors of sight and
sound, and as long
as you live

The source of life
Is as a mother.
Be fond of both
mother and
children but
know the mother
dearer And you
outlive death.
Curb your tongue
and senses And
you are beyond
trouble, Let them
loose And you

you will have no
vexation. But open
your mouth, or
become
inquisitive, and
you will be in
trouble all your life
long. To perceive
things in the germ
is intelligence. To
remain gentle is to
be invincible.
Follow the light
that guides you
homeward, and do
not get lost in the
darkness. This I
call using the
eternal. up

are beyond help.
Discover that
nothing is too
small for clear
vision, Too
insignificant for
tender strength~
Use outlook And
insight, Use them
both And you are
immune: For you
have witnessed
eternity.

Chapter 53

Ah that I were
wise enough to
follow the great
Tao!
Administration is
a great
undertaking. The
great Tao is
extremely
simple, but the
people prefer the
complex ways.
While the palace
is extremely well
appointed, the f

If I had any
learning Of a
highway wide
and fit, Would I
lose it at each
turning? Yet look
at people
spurning Natural
use of it! See
how fine the
palaces And see
how poor the
farms, How bare
the peasants'
granaries While
gentry wear
embroideries

The beginning of
the universe, when
materialized, is
considered to be a
mother. When a
man finds the
mother, he will
know the children,
accordingly. Even
though he knows
the children, he
still clings to the
mother: Therefore,
although his body
waned, he never
perishes. The
person who shuts
his mouth and
closes his doors
Will neve

ields may be full
of tares, and the
granaries may be
empty. To dress
grandly, to carry
sharp swords, to
eat and drink
excessively, and
to amass great
wealth, this I call
stylish theft. That
it is not Tao is
certain. up

Hiding
sharpened arms,
And the more
they have the
more they seize,
How can there
be such men as
these Who never
hunger, never
thirst, Yet eat
and drink until
they burst! There
are other
brigands, but
these are the
worst Of all the
highway's harms.

r perish. If he
opens his mouth
and increases his
affairs, He will
never be saved.
The person who
sees the tiniest
thing possesses
clear vision, The
person who
adheres to the
weak possesses
strength. Use your
light, but dim your
brightness, In this
way you will not do
yourself any harm.
This is called
following the
eternal Tao. up

Chapter 54

He who plants
rightly never
uproots. He who
lays hold rightly
never relinquishes.
His posterity will
honour him
continually.
Whoever develops
the Tao in himself
will be rooted in
virtue. Whoever
develops the Tao
in his family will
cause his virtue to
spread. Whoever
develops the Tao
in his village will
increase
prosperity.
Whoever develops
the Tao in the
kingd

'Since true
foundation cannot
fail But holds as
good as new,
Many a worshipful
son shall hail A
father who lived
true.' Realized in
one man, fitness
has its rise;
Realized in a
family, fitness
multiplies;
Realized in a
village, fitness
gathers weight;
Realized in a
country, fitness
becomes grea

Let me have
knowledge and
follow the great
way of the Tao, I
alone am afraid of
straying from this
path. The great
way is easy and
simple, But people
prefer byways.
The royal palaces
are wonderfully
maintained, But
the people's fields
are full of thorns,
And the barns are
empty. Th

om will make good
fortune prevail.
Whoever develops
Tao in the world
will make virtue
universal. I
observe myself,
and so I come to
know others. I
observe my family,
and all others grow
familiar. I study
this world, and
others come within
my knowledge.
How else should I
come to know the
laws which govern
all things, save
thus, that I
observe them in
myself? up

t; Realized in the
world, fitness fills
the skies. And thus
the fitness of one
man You find in
the family he
began, You find in
the village that
accrued, You find
in the country that
ensued, You find
in the world's
whole multitude.
How do I know this
integrity? Because
it could all begin in
me.

ere are those who
wear expensive
clothes, There are
those who carry
polished swords,
There are those
who gorge
themselves on
food and drink,
There are those
who amass
property and
possessions: This
is called
encouraging the
robbers. Is this not
straying from the
path of the Tao?
up

Chapter 55

The man who is saturated with Virtue is like a little child. Scorpions will not sting him, wild beasts will not seize him, nor will birds of prey pluck at him. His young bones are not hard, neither are his sinews strong, yet his grasp is firm and sure. He is full of vitality, though unconscious of his sex. Though he should cry out all day, yet he is never hoarse. Herein is sh

He whom life fulfills, Though he remains a child, Is immune to the poisonous sting Of insects, to the ravening Of wild beasts or to vultures' bills. He needs no more bone or muscle than a baby's for sure hold. Without thought of joined organs, he is gender Which grows firm, unfaltering. Though his voice should cry out at full pitch all day

What is sown by the best sower will never be uprooted, What is fastened by the best fastener will never be loosened. And so his children and grandchildren can continue the ancestral ritual for many generations. If he nurtures the Tao by himself, his virtue is genuine, If he nurtures the Tao in his family, his virtue is abundant, If he nurtures the Tao in his village, his virtue is inestimable, If he nurtures the Tao in his country

own his harmony with Nature. The knowledge of this harmony is the eternal Tao. The knowledge of the eternal Tao is illumination. Habits of excess grow upon a man, and the mind, giving way to the passions, they increase day by day. And when the passions have reached their climax, they fall. This is against the nature of Tao. And what is contrary to Tao soon comes to an end. up

, it would not rasp but would stay tender Through the perfect balancing Of a man at endless ease with everything Because of the true life that he has led. To try for more than this bodes ill. It is said, 'there's a way where there's a will;' But let life ripen and then fall. Willis not the way at all: Deny the way of life and you are dead.

Chapter 56

He who knows
the Tao does not
discuss it, and
those who
babble about it
do not know it.
To keep the lips
closed, to shut
the doors of sight
and sound, to
smooth off the
corners, to
temper the glare,
and to be on a
level with th

Those who know
do not tell, Those
who tell do not
know. Not to set
the tongue loose
But to curb it, Not
to have edges
that catch But to
remain
untangled,
Unblinded,
Unconfused, Is

The person who is
blessed with great
virtue can be
compared to a
child. He will not
be bitten by an
insect or a snake,
He will not be
devoured by wild
animals, Birds of
prey will not swoop
down on him. His
bones are fragile,
his tendons soft,
but his grip is
strong. He is not
familiar with the
union of man and
woman, but he
possesses
reproductive
powers. This
means that he i

e dust of the
earth, this is the
mysterious
virtue. Whoever
observes this will
regard alike both
frankness and
reserve,
kindness and
injury, honour
and degradation.
For this reason
he will be held in
great esteem of
all men. up

to find balance,
And he who
holds balance
beyond sway of
love or hate,
Beyond reach of
profit or loss,
Beyond care of
praise or blame,
Has attained the
highest post in
the world.

s at the peak of his
vitality. He can
weep all day and
not become
hoarse. This
means that he is in
perfect harmony.
Being familiar with
this harmony
brings him closer
to eternity, Being
familiar with
eternity enables
man to attain
enlightenment.
Increasing life
invites trouble, Let
your heart become
addicted to the
breath of the spirit,
and you will be
filled with potency.
up

Chapter 57

A realm is governed by ordinary acts, A battle is governed by extraordinary acts; The world is governed by no acts at all. And how do I know? This is how I know. Act after act prohibits Everything but poverty, Weapon after weapon conquers Everything but chaos, Business after business provides A craze of waste, Law

Make all the weapons blunt, Cut everything that is tangled, Make everything that is shiny dull, Mix with anything that is as humble as dust, And this is called absolute equality. Therefore One cannot get close to it Nor can

ore do artificial things come into use. And when those cunning arts are publicly esteemed, then do rogues prosper. Therefore the wise man says:- I will design nothing: and the people will shape themselves. I will keep quiet; and the people will find their rest. I will not assert myself; and the people will come forth. I will discountenance ambition; and the people will revert to their natural simplicity. up

after law breeds A multitude of thieves. Therefore a sensible man says: If I keep from meddling with people, they take care of themselves, If I keep from commanding people, they behave themselves, If I keep from preaching at people, they improve themselves, If I keep from imposing on people, they become themselves.

one get away from it. It is impossible to derive benefit from it, Nor to be harmed by it. It does not publicize a person's honor, Nor does it publicize a person's shame. Therefore it is the most exalted thing in the world. up

Chapter 58

A free and generous government gives the people a chance to develop. When a government is rigid and exacting the people are cramped and miserable. Misery is but the shadow of happiness. Happiness is but the cloak of misery. When will there be an end to them? If we dispense with rectitude, distortion will assert itself; and what was good in its

The less a leader does and says The happier his people, The more a leader struts and brags The sorrier his people. Often what appears to be unhappiness is happiness And what appears to be happiness is unhappiness. Who can see what leads to what When happiness appears and yet is

way will give place to what is evil. Verily the people have been under a cloud for a long time. Therefore the wise man is full of rectitude, but he does not chirp and carve at others. He is just, but he does not admonish others. He is upright, but he does not straighten others. He is enlightened, but he does not offend with his brightness. up

not, When what should he is nothing but a mask Disguising what should not be? Who can but ask An end to such a stupid plot! Therefore a sound man shall so square the circle And circle the square as not to injure, not to impede: The glow of his life shall not daze, It shall lead.

Chapter 59

In ruling men and
in serving Heaven
there is nothing
like moderation.
By means of it one
attains to his first
estate. When this
is attained a man
is possessed of an
indefinite store of
virtue. With such a
store of virtue he
will overcome
everything. And of
this ma

To lead men and
serve heaven,
weigh the worth
Of the one
source: Use the
single force
Which doubles
the strength of
the strong By
enabling man to
go right,
disabling him to
go wro

When the
government is
indifferent and
inactive, The
people will be
happy and
wealthy, When the
government
discriminates and
divides, The
people will be
restless and
dissatisfied.
Happiness is
borne on the back
of sorrow, Sorrow
dwells beneath
happiness.
Therefore, who
can know the
virtues of good
government? Only
when the
government doe

stery there will be
no limit. Thus,
without hindrance,
he may possess
the Kingdom. Such
a man has the mot
her-constitution,
and will endure
indefinitely. He is
like the plant
whose roots are
deep and whose
stem is firm. Thus
may a man live
long and see many
days. up

ng, Be so
charged with the
nature of life that
you give your
people birth,
That you mother
your land, are
the fit And
ever-iving root of
it: The
seeing.root,
whose eye is
infinite.

s not rectify
anything.
Otherwise, the
rectification
becomes a
strategy, And good
becomes evil.
People have been
aware of this for a
long time.
Therefore the sage
is square and does
not cut others, He
has a point, but he
does not pierce
others, He is
straight, but he
does not
straighten others,
He shines, but he
does not dazzle
others. up

Chapter 60

The state should be governed as we cook small fish, without much business. Bringing the Tao to the governing of the Kingdom will give rest to the shades of the dead. Not that the Spirits will be inactive, but they will

Handle a large kingdom with as gentle a touch as if you were cooking small fish. If you manage people by letting them alone, Ghosts of the dead shall not haunt you. Not that there are

When ruling people, like serving heaven, the sage acts only in moderation. Only with moderation can he learn the Tao in an instant. This study is called "the rapid accumulation of a virtue." Through the rapid accumulation of a virtue He can overcome everything. Since there is nothing he cannot overcome,

I cease to trouble the people. But what is of more importance, the wise ruler of the people will not hurt them. And in so far as they do not interfere with one another, their influences conspire to the general good! up

no ghosts But that their influence becomes propitious In the sound existence of a living man: There is no difference between the quick and the dead, They are one channel of vitality.

No one can know of his superiority. Since no one knows of his superiority, He can rule the country. Since what he does when he acquires everything is identified with the mother, his days are extended. Thus his roots are deep and his foundations strong, and he knows the way of longevity and immortality. up

Chapter 61

The kingdom, like a river, becomes great by being lowly; it is thereby the centre to which all the world tends. It is similar in the case of woman: She conquers man by continual quietness. And quietness is the same as submission. Therefore a great state, by condescension to those beneath it, may gain the government of them. Likewise a

A large country is the low level of interflowing rivers. It draws people to the sea-end of a valley As the female draws the male, Receives it into absorbing depth Because depth always absorbs. And so a large country, inasfar as it is deeper than a small country, Absorbs the small- Or a small country, inasfar as it is

Govern a large country as you would cook a small fish, gently. Let the Tao govern the world, and spirits will not roam freely. This does not mean that spirits will not have powers, But rather that their powers will not harm people. They will no

small state, by submission to one that is greater, may secure its alliance. Thus the one gains adherence, and the other obtains favours. Although the great state desires to annex and to nourish others, yet the small state desires to be allied to and serve the greater. Thus both will be satisfied, if only the greater will condescend. up

deeper than a large country, Absorbs the large. Some countrnes consciously seek depth into which to draw others. Some countries naturally have depth into which to draw others: A large country needs to admit, A small country needs to emit, And so each country can naturally have what it needs If the large country submit.

t harm people, Nor will the sage harm people. When neither he nor they harm anybody, The virtue belongs to both of them. When the Tao governs the world, the spirits are not known as spirits and the sage is not considered a sage, says Wang-Pi. up

Chapter 62

Tao is the secret guardian of all things. It enriches the good man and forbids the evildoer. Its counsel is always in season; its benevolence is always in demand. Even those who are not good it does not forsake. Therefore, when the Emperor takes his throne and appoints his nobles, he who comes before him bearing the insignia

Existence is sanctuary: It is a good man's purse, It is also a bad man's keep. Clever performances come dear or cheap, Goodness comes free; And how shall a man who acts better deny a man who acts worse This right to be. Rather, when an emperor is crowned, let the three Ministers w

A great country is like the drainage basin of the entire world, Into which all the rivers flow, It is the field of the entire world, It is the femininity of the entire world. Femininity always overcomes masculinity with its calmness of spirit, Which it uses as a means to lower itself. Thus the great country lowers itself before the small country, Before it conquers the small country. A small country lowers itself

of a prince and escorted by a mounted retinue is not to be compared with one who humbly presents this Tao. For why did the ancients hold it in such esteem? Was it not because it could be had without much seeking, and because by means of it man might escape from sin? For this it was esteemed the greatest thing in the world. up

hom he appoints to receive for him fine horses and gifts of jade Receive for him also the motionless gift of integrity, The gift prized as highest by those ancients who said, 'Only pursue an offender to show him the way.' What men in all the world could have more wealth than they?

before a great country, Before it conquers the great country. Therefore some lower themselves to take, And others lower themselves to gather. The only wish of a great country is to hold on to and keep its endless subjects, And the only wish of a small country is to engage in many occupations and tasks. When they both wish to realize their aspirations, Both of them together, The greater of them must lower itself. up

Chapter 63

Acting without design, occupying oneself without making a business of it, finding the great in what is the small, and the many in the few, repaying injury with kindness, effecting difficult things while they are easy, and managing great things in their beginnings, is the method of Tao. All difficult things have their origin in that which

Men knowing the way of life Do without acting, Effect without enforcing, Taste without consuming; 'Through the many they find the few, Through the humble the great;' They 'respect their foes,' They 'face the simple fact before it becomes involved, Solve the small problem before it becomes big.' The most involved fact in the world Could have been f

The Tao is the source of everything, The treasure of the good man, The sustainer of the bad man. Therefore, Even the ceremonial splendor of the coronation of the emperor and his three ministers, And the value of the jewels and the knights' horses, Are nothing compared to the splen

h is easy, and the great things in that which is small. Therefore the wise man can accomplish great things without even attempting them. He who lightly assents will seldom keep his word. He who accounts all things easy will have many difficulties. Therefore the Sage takes great account of small things, and so never has any difficulty. up

aced when it was simple, The biggest problem in the world Could have been solved when it was small. The simple fact that he finds no problem big Is a sane man's prime achievement. If you say yes too quickly You may have to say no, If you think things are done too easily You may find them hard to do: If you face trouble sanely It cannot trouble you.

dor of this Tao. Why did the ancients value the Tao? Is it because it is possible to seek it and find it and liberate sinners with it? For this reason, the Tao is the most valuable thing in the world. Good words will nurture our honor, Good deeds will give a person a good name. up

Chapter 65

The ancients who practiced the Tao did not make use of it to render the people brilliant, but to make them simple and natural. The difficulty in governing the people is through overmuch policy. He who tries to govern the kingdom by policy is only a scourge to it; while he who gov

Sound old rulers, it is said, Left people to themselves, instead Of wanting to teach everything And start the people arguing. With mere instruction in command, So that people understand Less than they know, woe is the land; But happy the land that is ordered so That th

In ancient times, the best Tao practitioners did not use it to educate the people, But rather to restore them to simplicity. It is difficult to govern people since they are very knowledgeable. Therefore, ruling a country by increasing knowledge Means destroying the country, While ruling a country b

erns without it is a blessing. To know these two things is the perfect knowledge of government, and to keep them continually in view is called the virtue of simplicity. Deep and wide is this simple virtue; and though opposed to other methods it can bring about a perfect order. up

ey understand more than they know. For everyone's good this double key Locks and unlocks equally. If modern man would use it, he Could find old wisdom in his heart And clear his vision enough to see From start to finish and finish to start The circle rounding perfectly.

y reducing knowledge Means blessing the country. The person who is aware of these two ways knows the standard, The person who keeps the standard in his mind is virtuous. The highest virtue is profound and broad, It goes back to the beginning of everything, And in this way attains absolute peace. up

Chapter 66

That by which the great rivers and seas receive the tribute of all the streams, is the fact of their being lowly; that is the cause of their superiority. Thus the Sage, wishing to govern the people, speaks of himself as beneath them; and wishing to lead them, pl

Why are rivers and seas lords of the waters? Because they afford the common level And so become lords of the waters. The common people love a sound man Because he does not talk above their level, Because

The best soldier does not love war, The best warrior is not bloodthirsty, The best conqueror does not take part in the war, The best employer places himself beneath his wor

aces himself behind them. So, while he is yet above them, they do not feel his weight; and being before them, he yet causes no obstruction. Therefore all men exalt him with acclamation, and none is offended. And because he does not strive, no man is his enemy. up

, though he lead them, He follows them, He imposes no weight on them; And they in turn, because he does not impede them, Yield to him, content: People never tire of anyone Who is not bent upon comparison.

kers. That is called the virtue of self-control, That is called the ability to be helped by others, That is called the enlightenment that comes from uniting with heaven. up

Chapter 67

Everyone says
that my way of life
is the way of a
simpleton. Being
largely the way of
a simpleton is
what makes it
worth while. If it
were not the way
of a simpleton It
would long ago
have been
worthless, These
possessions of a
simpleton being
the three I choose
And cherish: To
care, To be fair, To
be humble. Wh

What the Tao is to
the world, So the
streams and
valleys are to the
rivers and seas.
Rivers and seas
can be like kings
to all the streams
and valleys Since
the former can
lower themselves
before the latter.
Thus they are the
kings of all the
streams and
valleys. Therefore
the sage, in order
to be above the
people, Must lower
himself before
them in words,
And in ord

generous. With
such humility I can
be great in service,
as a vessel of
honour. But in
these days men
forsake gentleness
and become only
obtrusive. They
abandon economy
and become only
excessive. They
relinquish humility
and strive for
precedence, and
thus for death.
Gentleness is ever
victorious in attack
and secure in
defence. Therefore
when Heaven
would preserve a
man it enfolds him
with gentleness.
up

en a man cares he
is unafraid When
he is fair he leaves
enough for others,
When he is
humble he can
grow; Whereas if,
like men of today,
he be bold without
caring,
Self-indulgent
without sharing,
Self-important
without shame, He
is dead. The
invincible shield Of
caring Is a weapon
from the sky
Against being
dead.

er to head the
people, He must
place himself
behind them in
body. Thus, when
he is above the
people, the people
do not suffer at his
hand, When he is
at the head of the
people, the people
are not held back
by him. Therefore
the whole world
wants to carry him
on its shoulders
And never tires of
him. He competes
with nobody, And
therefore nobody
competes with
him. up

Chapter 68

The good
commander is
not imperious.
The good fighter
is not wrathful.
The greatest
conqueror does
not wage war.
The best master
governs by
condescension.

The best captain
does not plunge
headlong Nor is
the best soldier a
fellow hot to
fight. The
greatest victor
wins without a
battle: He who
overcomes men
unders

This is the virtue
of not
contending. This
is the virtue of
persuasion. This
is the imitation of
Heaven, and this
was the highest
aim of the
ancients. up

tands them.
There is a quality
of quietness
Which quickens
people by no
stress:
'fellowship with
heaven,' as of
old, Is fellowship
with man and
keeps its hold.

Chapter 69

A great warrior has said, "I dare not be the host, I would rather be the guest; I dare not advance an inch, I would rather retire a foot." Now this I call filling in without marshalling the ranks; baring the arms without preparing to fight; grasping the sword without unsheathing it; and advancing

The handbook of the strategist has said: 'Do not invite the fight, accept it instead,' 'Better a foot behind than an inch too far ahead,' Which means: Look a man straight in the face and make no move, Roll up your sleeve and clench no fist, Open you

A tactician in ancient times said: "I do not dare to act as a host, I prefer to act as a guest, I do not dare to advance an inch, I prefer to retreat a foot." This implies that he does not muster his armies, as if he has no armies, He does not roll up his sleeves, as if his arms are not ready, He does not go out to battle, a

ing upon the enemy without coming into conflict. There is nothing so unfortunate as entering lightly into battle. For in doing so we are in danger of losing that which is most precious. Thus it happens that when opposing forces meet in battle, he who feels the pity of is assuredly conquers. up

r hand and show no weapon, Bare your breast and find no foe. But as long as there be a foe, value him, Respect him, measure him, be humble toward him; Let him not strip from you, however strong he be, Compassion, the one wealth which can afford him.

s if he has no weapons, He does not fight, as if he has no enemies. The greatest calamity is to underestimate the strength of the enemy, For underestimating the strength of the enemy leads to the loss of our treasure of love. Therefore, when armies clash on the battlefield, The one that possesses the treasure will triumph. up

Chapter 70

Easy are my words to know, and also to practice. Yet none is able to understand nor yet to practice them. For there is a remote origin for my words, and a supreme law for my ac

My way is so simple to feel, so easy to apply, That only a few will feel it or apply it. If it were not the lasting way, the natural way to try, If it were a passing way, everyone wou

Words have an ancestor, deeds have a master. It is easy to understand my words and practice them. But all the people in the world do not know them, And do not practice them. Since they have knowledge, they do not know me. When those that know me are few, I a

tions. Not knowing these, men cannot know me. Those who know me are few, and by them I am esteemed. For the wise man is outwardly poor, but he carries his jewel in his bosom. up

Id try it. But however few shall go my way Or feel concerned with me, Some there are and those are they Who witness what they see: Sanity is a haircloth sheath With a jewel underneath.

m beyond all praise. Therefore the sage wears coarse woolen clothes but carries jade jewels in his bosom, He knows himself, but does not present himself, He loves himself, but does not act arrogantly. Therefore he rejects the latter and adopts the former. up

Chapter 71

To know one's
ignorance is the
best part of
knowledge. To
be ignorant of
such knowledge
is a disease. If
one only regards
it as a di

A man who
knows how little
he knows is well,
A man who
knows how much
he knows is sick.
If, when you see
the symptoms,
yo

Not knowing
what one knows
is the best, To
think that one
knows when one
does not know is
sick. Only when
one becomes
sick of this

sease, he will
soon be cured of
it. The wise man
is exempt from
this disease. He
knows it for what
it is, and so is
free from it. up

u can tell, Your
cure is quick. A
sound man
knows that
sickness makes
him sick And
before he
catches it his
cure is quick.

sickness, Is it
possible to get
free of the
sickness. The
sage is never
sick, Since he is
sick of this
sickness, He is
not sick. up

Chapter 72

When men do not have a right fear of present dangers, they run into extremes of peril. Let them beware of enlarging the house, being wary of present conditions. If they do not despise it, no such

Upon those who defy authority It shall be visited, But not behind prison walls Nor through oppression of their kin; Men sanely led Are no

If the people do not fear the ruling authority, A much greater fear will befall them. Be sure that you do not make them live in crow

weariness will arise. This is why the Sage, while possessed of self-knowledge, does not parade himself. He loves, but does not value himself highly. Thus he can put away pride, and is content. up

t led by duress. To know yourself and not show yourself, To think well of yourself and not tell of yourself, Be that your no and your yes.

ded quarters Or make their lives unbearable. Only when their living quarters are not crowded Will their dissatisfaction disappear. up

Chapter 73

He whose courage is expressed in daring will soon meet death. He whose courage is shown in self-restraint will be preserved. There are, then, two kinds of courage; the one is injurious and the other of advantage. But who is to say why one of them should incur the judgement of Heaven? That is why the Sage finds it

A man with outward courage dares to die, A man with inward courage dares to live; But either of these men Has a better and a worse side than the other. And who can tell exactly to which qualities heaven objects? Heave

The person who shows courage in daring will perish. The person who shows courage in a lack of daring will live. To know these two things means to differentiate between the one, which is beneficial, and the other, which is harmful. Who knows that heaven loathes one of them? The superio

difficult to act. The celestial Tao does not strive, and yet overcomes everything. It does not speak, yet is skilful in replying. It does not call, yet things come to it readily. It is quiet in its methods, yet its plans are thoroughly effective. The net of Heaven has large meshes, and yet nothing escapes it! up

n does nothing to win the day, Says nothing-Is echoed, Orders nothing-Is obeyed, Advises nothing-Is right: And which of us, seeing that nothing is outside the vast Wide-meshed net of heaven, knows just how it is cast?

r Tao does not fight, yet it wins for certain. It does not speak, yet it responds to everything. It does not call, yet everyone comes to hear it. It is not a tactician, yet it makes plans. Heaven's net is all-embracing, and its holes are wide, And even so, nothing escapes its sweep. up

Chapter 74

When the people
do not fear
death, of what
use is it to
overawe them
with it as a
penalty? And if
they were always
held in fear of
death, and I
could lay my
hand upon all
evil doers and
slay them, w

People starve If
taxes eat their
grain, And the
faults of starving
people Are the
fault of their
rulers. That is
why people
rebel. Men who

When people do
not fear death,
What is the use
of frightening
them with the
death penalty?
When people are
constantly afraid
of death, And we
can arrest and
execute
criminals, Who
would dare to
commit crimes?
Onl

ould I dare to do
it? There is
always the Great
Executioner! For
one to usurp that
office is like a
novice cutting
out the work of a
great architect.
Such a one
rarely fails to cut
his own hands!
up

have to fight for
their living And
are not afraid to
die for it Are
higher men than
those who,
stationed high,
Are too fat to
dare to die.

y the executioner
kills. To kill
instead of the
executioner is
like a woodcutter
taking a master-c
arpenter's place.
When someone
carves instead of
the master-carpe
nter, He can
usually expect to
injure his hand.
up

Chapter 75

The people
suffer from
famine on
account of the
heavy taxation
put upon them.
This is the cause
of their need.
The people are
difficult to govern
because of the
overbearing of
their superiors.
This is the cause
of their

Death is no
threat to people
Who are not
afraid to die; But
even if these
offenders feared
death all day,
Who should be
rash enough To
act as
executioner?
Nature is ex

The people are
starving,
Because their
clerks impose
heavy taxes on
them. That is
why they are
starving. It is
difficult to govern
the people,
Because their
clerks interfere in

trouble. The
people make
light of dying
because of the
great hardships
of trying to live.
This is the
reason for their
indifference to
death. Therefore
to keep living in
obscurity is
better than
making
overmuch of it.
up

ecutioner. When
man usurps the
place, A
carpenter's
apprentice takes
the place of the
master: And 'an
apprentice
hacking with the
master's axe
May slice his
own hand.'

their affairs. That
is why they are
difficult to
govern. The
people do not
respect death,
Because their
clerks direct
them to seek life.
That is why they
do not respect
death. up

Chapter 76

Man at his birth is supple and tender, but in death he is rigid and strong. It is the same with everything. Trees and plants in their early growth are pliant and soft, but at the end they are withered and tough. Thus rigidity and strength are concomitants of death, but so

Man, born tender and yielding, Stiffens and hardens in death. All living growth is pliant, Until death transfixes it. Thus men who have hardened are 'kin of death' And m

The living person is soft and pliant, and is hard and rigid in death. All creatures and plants, Are soft and vulnerable in life, And dry and brittle in death. Therefore it is said: The hard and the rigid are part of death, The soft and

fitness and gentleness are companions of life. Therefore the warrior who relies on his strength cannot conquer death, while the powerful tree becomes a mere timber support. For the place of the strong and the firm is below, while that of the gentle and yielding is above. up

en who stay gentle are 'kin of life.' Thus a hard-hearted army is doomed to lose. A tree hard-fleshed is cut down: Down goes the tough and big, Up comes the tender sprig.

gentle are part of life. This is the reason why soldiers who are too rigid Do not triumph. When the tree is too rigid, it will break. The stance of the strong and the great is stooped, The stance of the weak and the small is erect. up

Chapter 77

Like the bending of an archer's bow is the Tao of Heaven! It brings down that which is high, and raises up that which is depressed. It takes away where there is excess, and gives where there is deficiency. The Tao of Heaven makes all things equal. This Tao is not of man. Man takes from

Is not existence like a drawn bow? The ends approach, The height shortens, the narrowness widens. True living would take from those with too much Enough for those with too little, Whereas man exacts from those with too little Still more for those who

Is not the superior Tao like drawing a bow? The high part moves downward, the low part moves upward, What is full is reduced, what is insufficient is filled. The superior Tao reduces the full, fills what is insufficient. Man's Tao, in contrast, takes from the insufficient and gives to the full. Who

man the needy to add to his own excess. Who is he that, having a superabundance, can bring it to the service of the world? Only he who has the Tao. This is why the wise man acts without expectation of reward, and completes his task without claiming merit. For thus he hides his wealth. Who

se with too much. Now what man shall have wealth enough to share with all men Save one who can freely draw from the common means? A sane man needs no better support, no richer reward, Than this common means, Through which he is all men's equal.

ho can take from the full and give to the insufficient? Only he who has the Tao can. Therefore, the sage does not hoard anything for himself. The more he helps others, the more he obtains for himself. The superior Tao does good, and never does evil, The sage's Tao acts, but never hurts others. up

Chapter 78

Nothing on earth is so weak and yielding as water, but for breaking down the firm and strong it has no equal. This admits of no alternative. All the world knows that the soft can wear away the hard, and the weak can conquer the strong, but

What is more fluid, more yielding than water? Yet back it comes again, wearing down the rigid strength Which cannot yield to withstand it. So it is that the strong are overcome by the weak, T

The weakest thing in the world can overcome the strongest thing in the world. Nothing in the world can compare with the weakness of water, whose nature is limp and submissive, But when it attacks the hardest and strongest of all, there is nothing more efficient, Since there is no alternative to it. The weak can overcome the strong, and the soft can

none can carry it out in practice. Therefore the Sage says: He who bears the reproach of his country is really the lord of the land. He who bears the woes of the people is in truth their king. The words of truth are always paradoxical. up

he haughty by the humble. This we know But never learn, So that when wise men tell us, 'He who bites the dust Is owner of the earth, He who is scapegoat Is king,' They seem to twist the truth.

conquer the tough: The whole world knows that, but does not abide by it. Therefore the sage says: The person who bears all the disgrace of the country can be the master of the land, The person who bears all the troubles of the country can be the king of the world. These are words of truth, Even though they sound like nothing more than a paradox. up

Chapter 79

When a compromise is effected after a long dispute, one of the parties retains a grudge: how can this be called a good settlement? Therefore the wise man takes his part of the bond, and does not insist upon h

If terms to end a quarrel leave bad feeling, What good are they? So a sensible man takes the poor end of the bargain Without

Give love in return for fierce hatred. Otherwise, when the fierce hatred is forgotten, A little of it will still remain. And how can this end well? Therefore the sage keeps the left half of a contract, And does not check what t

aving the other. The virtuous man attends only to his engagements in the bond, while the man without virtue contrives for his own advantage. The Tao of Heaven has no favourites; it always aids the good man. up

quibbling. It is sensible to make terms, Foolish to be a stickler: Though heaven prefer no man, A sensible man prefers heaven.

he other holder has to do. The virtuous person acts according to the contract, The person who is not virtuous resorts to lawsuits and disputations. "The superior Tao is not biased, It always accompanies the virtuous person." up

Chapter 80

If I had a small kingdom and but ten or a hundred men of ability, I would not administrate with them. I would teach the people to look upon death as a grievous thing, and then they would not go abroad to meet it. Though they had boats and carriages, yet they would not go away in them. Though they had armour, yet they would never have occasion to wear it. The people would return to the use of

If a land is small and its people are few, With tenfold enough to have and to do, And if no one has schooled them to waste supply In the country for which they live and would die, Then not a boat, not a cart Tempts this people to depart, Not a dagger, not a bow Has to be drawn or bent for show, People reckon by knots in a cor

Imagine a small land with few people. Even if it contains plenty of vessels, I will not use them. I will induce the people to respect death, and not to go wandering far afield. Even if they have boats and chariots, they will not travel in them, Even if they have weapons and armor, they will not bear them. I will bring them back to knotted cords instead of writ

the quipu. They should find their coarse food sweet, think their plain clothes grand, regard their homes as places of rest, and take delight in their own simple pleasures. Though the neighbouring state could be seen by us, and the crowing of the cocks and the barking of the dogs could be heard, Yet my people would grow old, and die before ever feeling the need of having intercourse with it. up

d, Relish plain food on the board, Simple clothing suits them well, And they remain content to dwell In homes their customs can afford. Though so close to their own town another town grow They can hear its dogs bark and its roosters crow, Yet glad of life in the village they know, Where else in the world shall they need to go?

ings. Their food will satisfy them, Their clothing will please them, Their dwellings will be full of tranquillity, Their customs will be full of happiness. Even though the neighboring lands are within view, And the crowing of the roosters and the barking of the dogs from there are audible, The people of that small country will not go there in their lifetime. up

Chapter 81

Sincere words
are not grand.
Grand words are
not faithful. The
man of Tao does
not dispute.
Those who know
it are not
learned. The
learned do not
know it. The wise
man does not lay
up treasure. The
more he expends
on others, th

He who knows
does not speak,
He who speaks
does not know.
He who speaks
the truth is not
arrogant, He who
is arrogant does
not speak the
truth. He who
has good
qualities does
not

e more he gains
for himself. The
more he gives to
others, the more
he has for his
own. This is the
Tao of Heaven,
which penetrates
but does not
injure. This is the
Tao of the wise
man, who acts
but does not
strive. [no
frames]

argue, He who
argues does not
have good
qualities. He who
has learned a lot
does not know,
He who knows
has not learned a
lot. Therefore the
sage does not
display his
qualities.